

LIVE



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ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

27th WEEK



INDIA - ISRAEL

UPSC CSE – GS II

**GS II ... BILATERAL GROUPINGS AND AGREEMENTS INVOLVING
INDIA AND AFFECTING INDIA'S INTERESTS.**

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Mr. Modi in Israel

He affirms special ties, underplays historical stress India has given to the Palestine issue

While welcoming Prime Minister Narendra Modi to Tel Aviv, his Israeli counterpart, Benjamin Netanyahu, said his country had awaited the visit for "seventy years". Since the birth in 1948 of Israel, whose admission to the UN India subsequently opposed, Israeli leaders had always sought full diplomatic ties. And once the Narasimha Rao government established full diplomatic ties in 1992, Israel pushed for full acknowledgement of bilateral relations on the international stage. As a result, the significance of Mr. Modi's visit to Israel, as the first Indian Prime Minister there, was the trip itself. This was reflected in the camaraderie between the two Prime Ministers, who spent practically every waking moment together. The agreements signed during the visit, on water, agriculture, space and science and technology, are important no doubt, but not path-breaking. They simply underscore ongoing cooperation in such fields — as well as in the defence sector, India being one of the biggest buyers of Israeli military equipment. Cooperation on cybersecurity issues, discussed by officials during Mr. Modi's visit, constitutes a breakthrough of sorts, given that Israel tends to limit cooperation in this area to a few countries. A decision was announced to upgrade ties to a strategic partnership, signalling a final step to total normalisation of relations. Perhaps this is why Mr. Modi's address to Israelis of Indian origin in Tel Aviv, with a promise to address visa issues and improve air connectivity, had an emotional pitch different from his meetings with the diaspora elsewhere in the world.

However, the best friendships are judged not just by bilateral bonhomie, but by the ability to discuss uncomfortable issues. With Mr. Modi's visit India has, for all purposes, de-hyphenated its ties with Israel and Palestine, something Israel has always wanted. In a clear repudiation of the Indian practice of keeping Palestinian leaders prominently in the loop, Mr. Modi made a point of not visiting the Occupied Territories. The departure was more prominent in the joint statement, that contained a short paragraph on the "Israel-Palestine" peace process, with no reference to UN resolutions, the two-state solution, or even the need to re-

THE  HINDU

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Mediterranean Sea

Cyprus

SYRIA

LEBANON

ISRAEL

IRAQ

JORDAN

EGYPT

SAUDI ARABIA

Gulf of Aqaba



INDIA - ISRAEL



POINTS OF DISCUSSION

- 1 The agreements signed in water, agriculture, space, S&T are important, but not path breaking
- 2 Decision on cooperation on cyber security, is no doubt a break through, as Israel limits such cooperation only to few countries.
- 3 Elevation of ties to strategic partnership, signals a final step towards normalisation of relations.
- 4 It de-hyphenated its ties with Israel and Palestine and it is clear departure from India's stated position
- 5 The PM not visited Palestine, which Donald Trump visited, when he went to Palestine
- 6 Joint Statement contained short paragraph on Israel-Palestine peace process, with no reference to UN resolutions.

It would have been more in keeping with Indian status on the international stage, and its particular leverage with all players in West Asia, had Mr. Modi made a visible attempt to extract from Israel a commitment to the peace process





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